to “normal” quantum physics.

Over the course of his talk, Dresden presented Bohm’s ideas and mathematics to his audience. When he finished, the moment he dreaded arrived: the floor was opened to questions from the room of luminaries. Dresden had offered to give this talk on less than a week’s notice and desperately hoped that he was prepared for what was sure to be a high-level technical discussion of someone else’s ideas.

Instead, to Dresden’s horror, the room erupted in vitriol. One person called Bohm a “public nuisance.” Another called him a traitor, still another said he was a Trotskyite. As for Bohm’s ideas, they were dismissed as mere “juvenile deviationism,” and several people implied that Dresden himself was at fault as a physicist to have taken Bohm seriously. Finally, Robert Oppenheimer, the director of the institute, spoke up. Oppenheimer was one of the most influential and famous physicists alive; he had led the Manhattan Project to success during the war, and he had mentored a blazingly brilliant team of physicists at Berkeley before that, including Bohm himself. Dresden watched in shock as Oppenheimer suggested to the room that “if we cannot disprove Bohm, then we must agree to ignore him.”

Bohm wasn’t there to defend his own ideas. He had been on the Princeton University faculty just a few months earlier, but now he was trapped in Brazil, exiled and blacklisted from his native country, while his former colleagues dismissed his new theory out of hand.

This story—Dresden’s discovery of Bohm’s paper, his visit to Princeton, the astonishingly obtuse responses of the physicists there—might be accurate. It’s certainly one of the stories that people tell about Bohm and the reception of his ideas; Oppenheimer’s supposed quote about ignoring Bohm has become particularly notorious. But there are a lot of stories that people tell about Bohm, many of which are poorly sourced or lacking sources entirely. These stories exist because, a quarter century after his death, David Bohm remains an intensely polarizing figure. He is written off as a kook, a deluded mystic, a hopelessly conservative throwback who wanted to return to the physics of Isaac Newton. He is also hailed as a visionary, the patron